Panicking, Macnaghten tried to escape, ‘like a pigeon fluttering to fly free from the grip of a hawk’. Akbar ‘grabbed him, drew his thirsty sword, then tore open the Envoy’s liver and lopped off his head. The headless corpse of the illustrious Saheb Macnaghten, the Chief Minister, like the carcase of a rabid dog, was dismembered and dragged into the city. It was then hung up, with his head and top hat, at the Four-Roofed Bazaar.’[121]

Colin Mackenzie, who was an eyewitness, gives a slightly different account. He wrote that, as a group of armed Afghans approached the seated party, Akbar Khan asked Macnaghten to move aside as he had something confidential to say to him. As Macnaghten leaned towards him, Akbar Khan suddenly screamed ‘Bigir! Bigir!’ meaning ‘Seize! Seize!’ at which he pinioned the Envoy. Akbar’s face wore an expression ‘of the most diabolical ferocity’ while Macnaghten’s face was ‘full of horror and astonishment’. Macnaghten cried ‘Az barae Khooda!’ – ‘For God’s sake’ – as Akbar caught him by his waist and tried at gunpoint to force him to mount the horse to go into the city with him. ‘The Envoy refused and said, “What do you wish to do with me?”’ Sultan Jan then said to Akbar, ‘Be quick otherwise we shall all be caught by the troops which are coming out from the cantonment.’ On this, Akbar Khan shot the Envoy with the double-barrelled pistol he had just been given. Macnaghten was still alive, but Akbar ordered his servant to finish him off with a jezail, and it was this which put an end to the life of the British Envoy. Akbar then had his head cut off, and ordered his body to be dragged through the streets along with that of Captain Trevor, who had been murdered by Sultan Jan.[122]

As soon as the violence began, Macnaghten’s personal escort of sixteen troopers fled, making no effort to rescue the officers.[123] As they were galloping back to the cantonment, they crossed the path of the delayed cavalry escort, which then also turned tail. ‘Not a man was despatched [from the cantonment],’ wrote Lawrence,

> nor a party sent out to reconnoitre; no sortie made, nor even a gun fired, though bodies of the enemy’s horse and foot were seen hurrying from the place of the conference towards Mahomed Khan’s fort, and several officers declared they could see distinctly through their field-glasses two bodies lying on the ground where the meeting took place. No attempt was made to recover them. Thus, almost within musket-shot of our entrenched position, and in broad daylight, a British envoy had been barbarously murdered, and his mangled body allowed to remain for hours where he fell, and finally carried off by a savage mob to be insulted in every possible way, and paraded throughout the city, without an attempt being made to save any of the party, or to avenge this unequalled outrage.[124]